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SEEKING THE RIGHT MENTORSHIP IN SPORTS

The impact of a great mentor can be one of the most powerful and **transformative** influences in one's career.

“The delicate balance of mentoring someone is not creating them in your own image but giving them the opportunity to create themselves.” — Steven Spielberg

What is it about mentorship that makes many so obsessive and at the same time doubtful?

Well, to start, I have been fortunate enough to be mentored by many high-quality professionals and well-wishing mentors at multiple stages of my career.

It is a culmination of their guidance, combined with our hard work and intelligence, that has brought me to where I am today.

As an emerging professional who took a 'non-traditional' path in both education and work, I am grateful for all the irreplaceable experiences given to me and, in some instances, shared with my peers.

These experiences have shaped my perspective. I have a distinctive outlook on why one should seek mentorship early in their professional career.

An alliance of individuals

The meaning of mentorship found

in academic literature goes beyond a standard Merriam-Webster definition. According to the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine; Policy and Global Affairs; Board on Higher Education and Workforce, mentorship can be defined as:

“A professional, working alliance in which individuals work together over time to support the personal and professional growth, development, and success of the relational partners through the provision of career and psychosocial support.”

But why do we need mentorship? The right mentor provides access to a trusted advisor who can offer proper guidance and support.

Mentors can assist in three major areas that can accelerate your career growth: professional, personal, and network development.

They can be your friend, philosopher, and guide, helping you embark on a well-structured and professional path. However, there are also negative aspects, which will be highlighted later.

Professional development

Mentors are invaluable sources of

experience and knowledge. Whether you're learning a hands-on skill or trying to understand a complicated topic, having a mentor to guide you is beneficial.

This direct feedback boosts confidence and enhances your professional development. Many mentors are walking encyclopaedias in their field, and the insights they provide can be crucial game-changers in one's career.

Personal upskilling

A combination of social skills, interpersonal abilities, character traits, and professional outlooks is essential for success in any career. Some of these attributes are inherent, while others — such as leadership, adaptability, effective communication, teamwork, and collaboration — can be nurtured under the right mentor's guidance.

Networking done right

Building a strong network is essential for a successful career. A mentor's network can help you expand your own domain of connections and references.

This is particularly valuable in niche